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The 5-Minute Shift Reset

A pocket guide for nurses
who bring the shift home with them.

burnouttobalanceguide.com

FIRST, THE TRUTH

Your shift ends. Your body doesn't get the memo.

Twelve hours of alarms, adrenaline, and holding it together for everyone else, and your nervous system is still in high alert. You replay the shift on the drive home. You snap at dumb stuff. You're exhausted but wired at 2am.

That's not a you problem. That's biology. Your body needs proof the emergency's over. That's what this is: five minutes, five steps, between the hospital doors and your actual life.

Car, locker room, porch. Wherever. The steps are tiny on purpose, because on the days you've got nothing left, tiny is the only thing that works.

THE PRACTICE

The 5-Minute Shift Reset

One minute each. Set a timer if you want.

1

The doorway breath (60 seconds)

Before you start the car: in for 4, hold for 4, out for 4, hold for 4. Four rounds. It's the fastest off-switch you've got.

2

Name it (60 seconds)

Finish this sentence out loud: "The heaviest part of today was..." Saying it out loud stops the 2am replay loop. You don't have to fix it. Just name it.

3

Move it out (60 seconds)

Shake out your hands. Roll your shoulders. Walk around the car once. Stress hormones were built for running from danger, and a 12-hour shift gives them nowhere to go. Sixty seconds of moving burns off what the shift stored up.

4

The handoff (60 seconds)

Say it once: "Shift's over. I did what I could with what I had." You hand off your patients. Hand off the shift too, or your brain keeps charting at midnight.

5

One small kindness (60 seconds)

Drink a full glass of water. Eat something real. Sit down before anyone can need you for anything. You spent 12 hours meeting everyone else's needs. One of yours first.

Try it for a week and see. Most nurses fall asleep faster and stop bringing the unit home with them. It won't fix a broken system. It'll give you your evenings back.

KNOW THE DIFFERENCE

When it's more than a bad shift

A reset helps after hard days. But if most days feel hard, pay attention. Burnout doesn't send a calendar invite. It creeps in:

- You're exhausted no matter how much you sleep.
- You feel detached from patients you used to care about.
- Small tasks feel massive. Everything feels like too much.
- You dread going in, even on a good unit with a good team.
- People who love you say you don't seem like yourself lately.

Three or more sound familiar? You're not failing. You're running on empty. And running on empty needs more than a breathing exercise. It needs an actual plan.

KEEP GOING

Burnout to Balance

Your 8-Step Guide to Thriving in a Messy Workplace.

How burnout actually works, why rest alone doesn't fix it,
and eight steps that get you from barely hanging on to steady.

Available on Amazon.

Search: Burnout to Balance by Andrea Gomez

burnouttobalanceguide.com

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